



GenEd1091



Week 12 Wrap up!

GenEd1091: Classical Chinese Philosophy and Political Theory



Applying Chinese Philosophy to the Classroom

Think about this classroom setting, what would it look like if...

1. We followed a more Confucian model of ritual and hierarchy?
2. We followed a more Daoist model of natural harmony and the Way?
3. We follow a more Legalist model of laws and punishments?



Experiment #1: Confucian classroom

1. Arrange your desks into small groups, identify the eldest in each group.
2. Elders, lead the members of your group to stand, bow, and say in unison, “*Good morning/afternoon teacher.*” Establish a basic set of rituals for your group (e.g. for participating, raising a question, objecting, etc.)
3. Discuss the following questions in accordance with your rituals:
 - a. What are your big takeaways about Chinese philosophy, ethics, and politics?
 - b. What skills have you learned about writing papers and textual analysis?
 - c. How did the combination of lecture and section work for you learning and education?
4. Students will be asked to volunteer and share their thoughts. Please stand and speak in a clear voice when participating.



Experiment #2: Daoist classroom

1. There is no seating arrangement. Feel free to sit at a desk or on the floor, as well as stand and move as you feel necessary.
2. Speak softly and move quietly. Avoid bringing attention to yourself.
3. Engage in one of the following activities (or come up with your own):
 - a. Draw a visual interpretation of one (or multiple) Chinese thinkers.
 - b. Write a journal entry reflecting on how different Chinese philosophies apply to your life.
 - c. Engage in a mindful or meditative activity to regulate your *qi*.



Experiment #3: Legalist classroom

1. Arrange your desk into neat rows facing the front of the classroom.
2. Sit with your back straight and only speak when given permission.
3. You will be shown passages from texts we have read in class. Everyone should guess and write down the text they think the passage is from.
4. The TF will call on students to share their answers.
5. This game will have the following rewards and punishments:
 - a. Correct guesses will be tallied, and rewarded with number of candies at the end.
 - b. Incorrect guesses will be penalized, students have to do one squat per wrong answer.



“When full, move quickly; when hungry, neglect your thoughts; when old, forget worry. If when full you don’t move quickly, vital energy will not circulate to your limbs. If when hungry you don’t neglect thoughts of food, when you finally eat you won’t stop. If when old you don’t forget your worries, the fount of your vital energy will rapidly drain out.”



“Follow what is correct and regular in ordering your state;
Follow what is strange and perverse in deploying your troops;
Follow no activity and gain the world.

How do I know that things are this way? Through this!

The more taboos and prohibitions there are in the world, the poorer the people.

The more sharp implements the people have, the more benighted the state.

The more clever and skillful the people, the more strange and perverse things arise. The more clear the laws and edicts, the more thieves and robbers.

And so sages say, “I do nothing and the people transform themselves;

I prefer stillness and the people correct and regulate themselves;

I engage in no activity and the people prosper on their own;

I am without desires and the people simplify their own lives.”



“Whenever the Master saw someone who was wearing mourning clothes, was garbed in full official dress, or was blind, he would always rise to his feet, even if the person was his junior. When passing such a person, he would always hasten his step.”



“If they employ men to make music, then these men must abandon their work of ploughing, planting, and cultivation. If they employ women to make music then these women must abandon their work of spinning, weaving, and sewing. These days, when kings, dukes, and great men put on musical performances, they divert such vast resources that could be used to produce food and clothing for the people.”



The Master said, “If you are respectful but lack ritual you will become exasperating; if you are careful but lack ritual you will become timid; if you are courageous but lack ritual you will become unruly; and if you are upright but lack ritual you will become inflexible.”



“[Floodlike qi] is a qi that is supremely great and supremely unyielding. If one cultivates it with uprightness and does not harm it, it will fill up the space between Heaven and earth. It is a qi that united righteousness with the Way. Without these, it starves. It is produced by accumulated righteousness. It cannot be obtained by a seizure of righteousness. If some of one’s actions leave one’s heart unsatisfied it will starve.”



“Little knowledge does not measure up to big knowledge, or few years to many. How do I know this is so? The morning mushroom does not know the waxing and waning of the moon, and the Hui-cricket does not know spring and fall. This is because they are short lived. South of Chu there is a turtle called Dark Genius, which counts five hundred years as a single spring and five hundred years as a single fall. In high antiquity there was a tree called Big Spring, which counted eight thousand years as a single spring and eight thousand years as a single fall. Nowadays, only eight-hundred- year-old Peng Zu is famous, and everyone compares themselves to him. Isn't it sad?”



“What is that by which humans are human? I say: It is because they have distinctions. Desiring food when hungry, desiring warmth when cold, desiring rest when tired, liking the beneficial and hating the harmful—these are things people have from birth. These one does not have to await, but are already so. These are what Yu and Jie both share. However, that by which humans are human is not that they are special in having two legs and no feathers, but that they have distinctions. [...] Of distinctions, none are greater than social divisions, and of social divisions, none are greater than rituals, and of rituals, one are greater than those of the sage-kings.”



“Therefore, if when examining gains and losses there is a system of laws and standards that can be applied to the claims and actions of the assembled ministers, the ruler will not be deceived by trickery and falsehood...”



“To lack a constant livelihood, yet to have a constant heart—only a scholar is capable of this. As for the people, if they lack a constant livelihood, it follows that they will lack a constant heart. [...] When there are benevolent people in positions of authority, how is it possible to trap the people? For this reason, an enlightened ruler, in regulating the people’s livelihood, must ensure that it is sufficient, on the one hand, to serve one’s father and mother, and on the other hand, to nurture wife and children. [...] Only when the people have a regulated livelihood do they rush toward the good, and thus the people follow the ruler easily.”



“The former kings, in making their interdicts, did not put to death [...] because they sought to harm those people, but with the object of prohibiting wickedness and stopping crime; for there is no better means of prohibiting wickedness and stopping crime than by making punishments heavy.”



“Our teacher X says, “Those who control great states will not attack small states. Those who control great families will not plunder lesser families. The strong will not rob the weak. The noble will not act arrogantly toward the humble. The clever will not deceive the foolish. Such things are beneficial to Heaven above, to ghosts and spirits in the middle realm, and to human beings below. Benefiting these three, there is none that is not benefitted, and so the best of names will be accorded to such men and they will be called ‘sage-kings.’”



“Punishment produces force, force produces strength, strength produces awe, awe produces virtue. Virtue has its origin in punishments...”



“Cut off sageliness, abandon wisdom, and the people will benefit one-hundred-fold.

Cut off benevolence, abandon righteousness, and the people will return to being filial and kind. Cut off cleverness, abandon profit, and robbers and thieves will be no more.

This might leave the people lacking in culture;
So give them something with which to identify:
Manifest plainness. Embrace simplicity.

Do not think just of yourself. Make few your desires.”



“For this reason, when an enlightened ruler hands out rewards it is generous, like the fall of timely rain, and the hundred surnames all benefit from his bounty. When he hands out penalties, it is terrifying, like thunder and lightning, and even spirits and sages cannot undo his work...”



“People’s nature is bad. Their goodness is a matter of deliberate effort. Now people’s nature is such that they are born with a fondness for profit. If they follow along with this, then struggle and contention will arise, and yielding and deference will perish therein. They are born with feelings of hate and dislike. If they follow along with these, then cruelty and villainy will rise, and loyalty and trustworthiness will perish therein. They are born with desires of the eyes and ears, a fondness for beautiful sights and sounds. If they follow along with these, then lasciviousness and chaos will arise, and ritual and the standards of righteousness, proper form and good order, will perish therein. Thus, if people follow along with their inborn nature and dispositions, they are sure to come to struggle and contention, turn to disrupting social divisions and disorder, and end up in violence. Looking at it in this way, it is clear that people’s nature is bad, and their goodness is a matter of deliberate effort.”



“Where sages wander, knowledge is a curse, restrictions are paste, favors are a patch, and effort is for trade. Sages do not plan, so why do they need knowledge? They do not cut, so why do they need paste? They have nothing to lose, so why do they need favors? They’re not buying, so why do they need trade? In these four ways they feed at Heaven. Feeding at Heaven, they are nourished by Heaven. Once they are nourished by Heaven, why do they need other people? They have human form but not human qing “essence.” Since they have human form, they flock with people. Since they lack human essence, right and wrong do not get to them. Infinitesimally small, they flock with people. Indescribably large, they complete their Heaven alone.”



“Simply return to the fundamentals. Suppose Your Majesty were to bestow benevolence in governing. This would cause all under Heaven who serve others to all want to take their place in Your Majesty’s court, those who plough to all want to plough in your Majesty’s uncultivated fields...”